

Rudy Gobert: Defensive Impact & DPOY Case (2025–26)

Caleb Ramsey

2026-01-19

1 Executive Summary

Rudy Gobert is still the backbone of Minnesota’s defense. When he’s on the floor the rim shrinks; when he sits the defense collapses. The Wolves still orbit him.

Offensively his role hasn’t changed, but he’s finishing at a career-best level inside. A four-time DPOY, he continues to carry a massive defensive workload and tilt games the way he has for nearly a decade.

2 Offense

2.1 Career Finishing Snapshot

Table 1: Career finishing by zone (Restricted Area vs Non-RA Paint).

Year	Paint FG%	Paint FGA	Paint FGM	RA FG%	RA FGA	RA FGM
2014	25%	4	1	51%	69	35
2015	20%	25	5	65%	392	253
2016	20%	35	7	61%	310	189
2017	24%	54	13	70%	565	398
2018	18%	57	10	70%	372	261
2019	35%	75	26	72%	626	449
2020	30%	53	16	74%	502	370
2021	17%	63	11	75%	505	379
2022	34%	58	20	77%	445	342
2023	31%	77	24	73%	458	334
2024	30%	88	26	74%	512	377
2025	24%	76	18	76%	427	323
2026	46%	37	17	77%	218	168

2.2 Career Finishing Trend

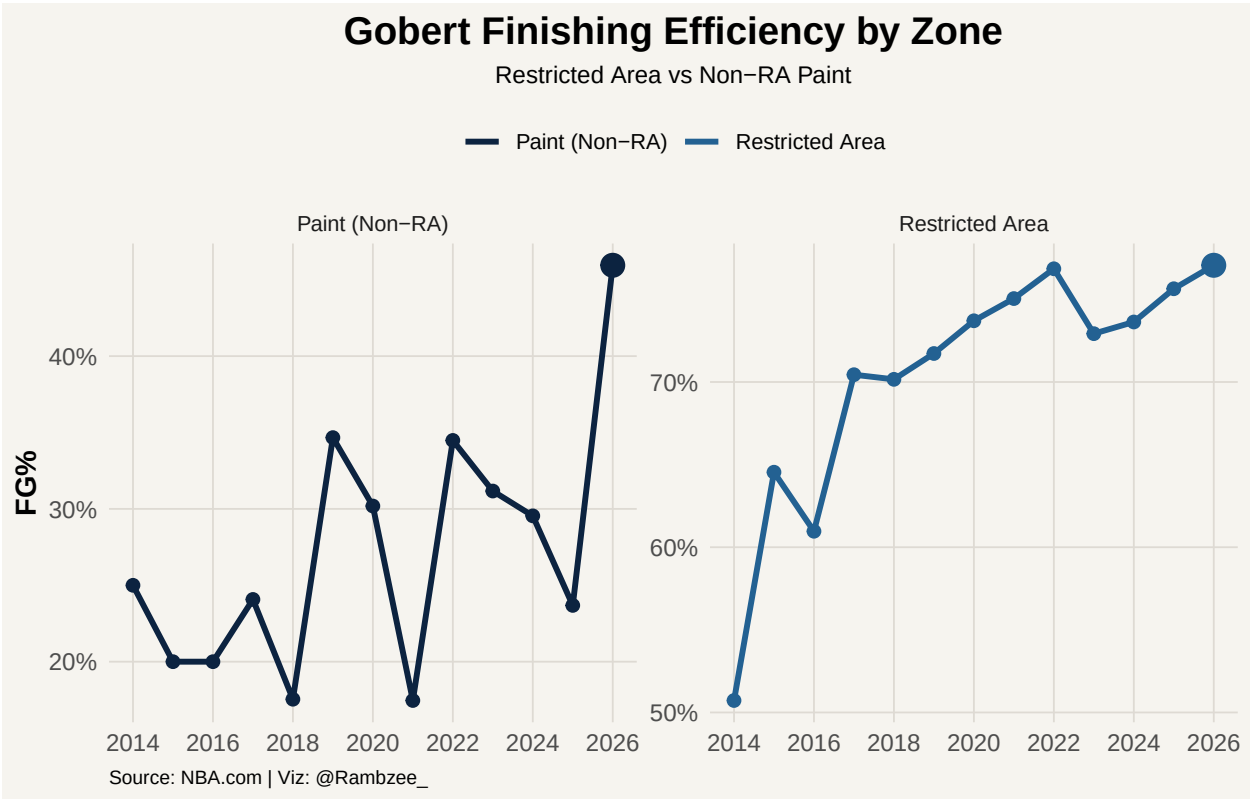


Figure 1: Rudy Gobert’s Finishing Across His Career

Gobert’s shot diet has always been simple, but Figure 1 shows a steady climb in restricted-area efficiency. Over his career, his finishing at the rim has gradually risen into the mid-70s, while his non-restricted-area paint efficiency (historically shaky) has been significantly better in 2025–26. He’s improved a bit with his touch, even at this stage of his career.

2.3 Other Impacts

He is averaging 3.9 offensive rebounds per game, accounting for 34.5% of Minnesota’s total (11.3), a major source of extra possessions. He also creates advantages as a screener, averaging 4.2 screen assists per game, second only to Jusuf Nurkić (4.6). These plays offset some of his limitations on the margins.

3 Defense

3.1 Team Impact

Table 2: Minnesota on/off with Gobert (ratings per 100 possessions).

Split	MIN	OffRtg	DefRtg	Net
Gobert ON	1231	116.8	108.1	+8.7
Gobert OFF	637	122.6	123.4	-0.8

3.2 DFG% Impact

\begin{table}[H] \caption{Total defensive FG% impact leaderboard (min 25 GP). Gobert ranks #11 of 15 (more negative = better).}

Rank	Player	Team	GP	DFGM/DFGA	Opp FG%	Expected FG%	Diff (pp)
1	Victor Wembanyama	SAS	28	174/440	39.5%	49.5%	-10.0
2	Duop Reath	POR	26	48/125	38.4%	47.3%	-8.9
3	Ariel Hukporti	NYK	25	53/133	39.8%	48.5%	-8.6
4	Jonathan Isaac	ORL	29	44/113	38.9%	47.2%	-8.2
5	Ajay Mitchell	OKC	41	125/335	37.3%	45.3%	-8.0
6	Chet Holmgren	OKC	37	216/530	40.8%	47.6%	-6.9
7	Steven Adams	HOU	31	158/369	42.8%	49.4%	-6.6
8	Paul Reed	DET	29	76/181	42.0%	48.4%	-6.4
9	Brook Lopez	LAC	34	131/306	42.8%	49.1%	-6.3
10	Jaren Jackson Jr.	MEM	38	241/578	41.7%	47.9%	-6.2
11	Rudy Gobert	MIN	41	307/708	43.4%	49.5%	-6.1
12	Jericho Sims	MIL	27	59/145	40.7%	46.7%	-6.0
13	Tyrese Proctor	CLE	26	41/103	39.8%	45.6%	-5.8
14	Julian Phillips	CHI	25	39/99	39.4%	45.2%	-5.8
15	Evan Mobley	CLE	37	276/639	43.2%	48.7%	-5.5

\end{table} \begin{table}[H] \caption{Rim-only defensive FG% impact leaderboard (min 25 GP, 100 defended). Gobert ranks #10 of 15.}

Rank	Player	Team	GP	DFGM/DFGA	Rim Opp FG%	Rim Expected FG%	Diff (pp)
1	Isaiah Stewart	DET	36	72/158	45.6%	62.7%	-17.2
2	Chet Holmgren	OKC	37	113/234	48.3%	63.3%	-15.0
3	Kevin Durant	HOU	37	76/154	49.4%	63.7%	-14.3
4	Trayce Jackson-Davis	GSW	29	50/101	49.5%	62.7%	-13.2
5	Dominick Barlow	PHI	30	70/139	50.4%	63.1%	-12.8
6	Adem Bona	PHI	31	58/112	51.8%	64.6%	-12.8
7	Brook Lopez	LAC	34	64/130	49.2%	61.9%	-12.7
8	Brandon Miller	CHA	25	73/142	51.4%	63.7%	-12.3
9	Jaden McDaniels	MIN	41	117/228	51.3%	63.5%	-12.2
10	Rudy Gobert	MIN	41	132/258	51.2%	63.3%	-12.1
11	Neemias Queta	BOS	38	103/197	52.3%	63.6%	-11.3
12	Nic Claxton	BKN	37	129/245	52.7%	63.6%	-10.9
13	Evan Mobley	CLE	37	153/287	53.3%	64.0%	-10.7
14	Ivica Zubac	LAC	35	109/202	54.0%	64.6%	-10.6
15	Quinten Post	GSW	43	82/153	53.6%	63.5%	-9.9

\end{table}

3.3 Total DFG% Leaderboard

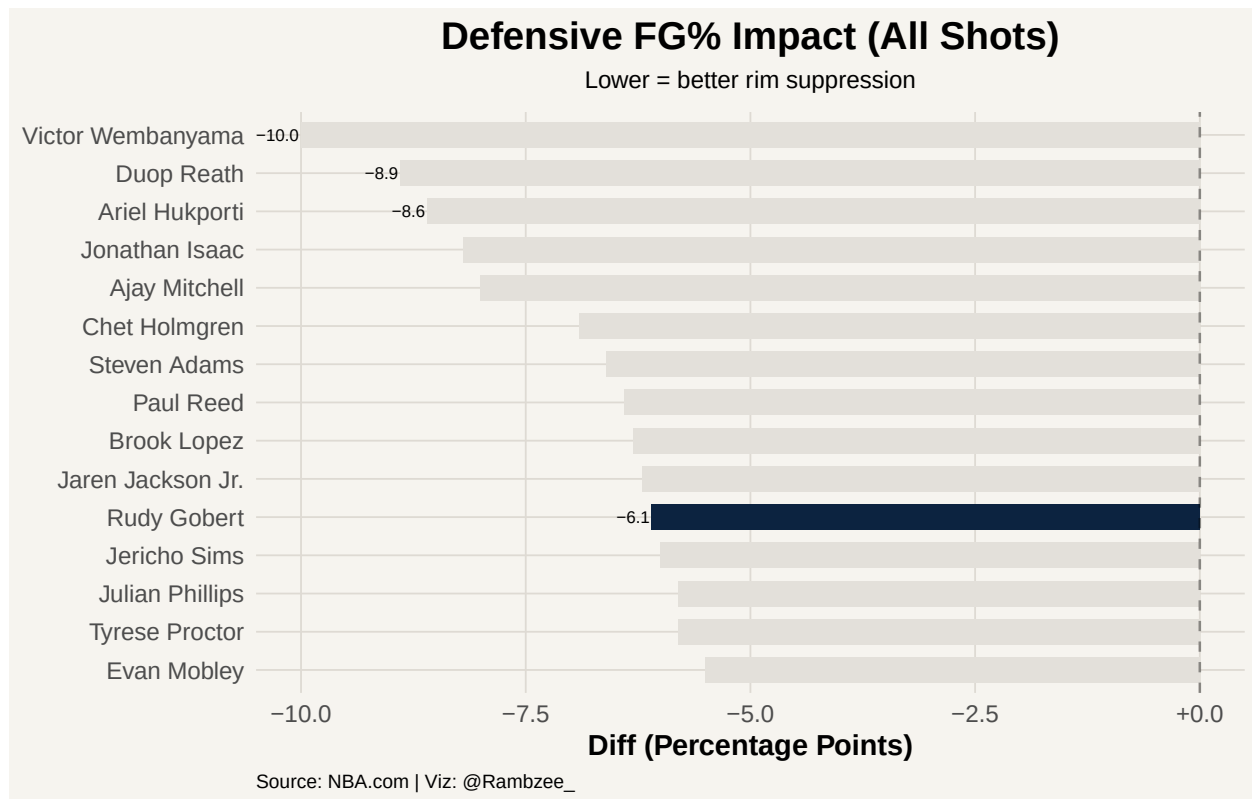
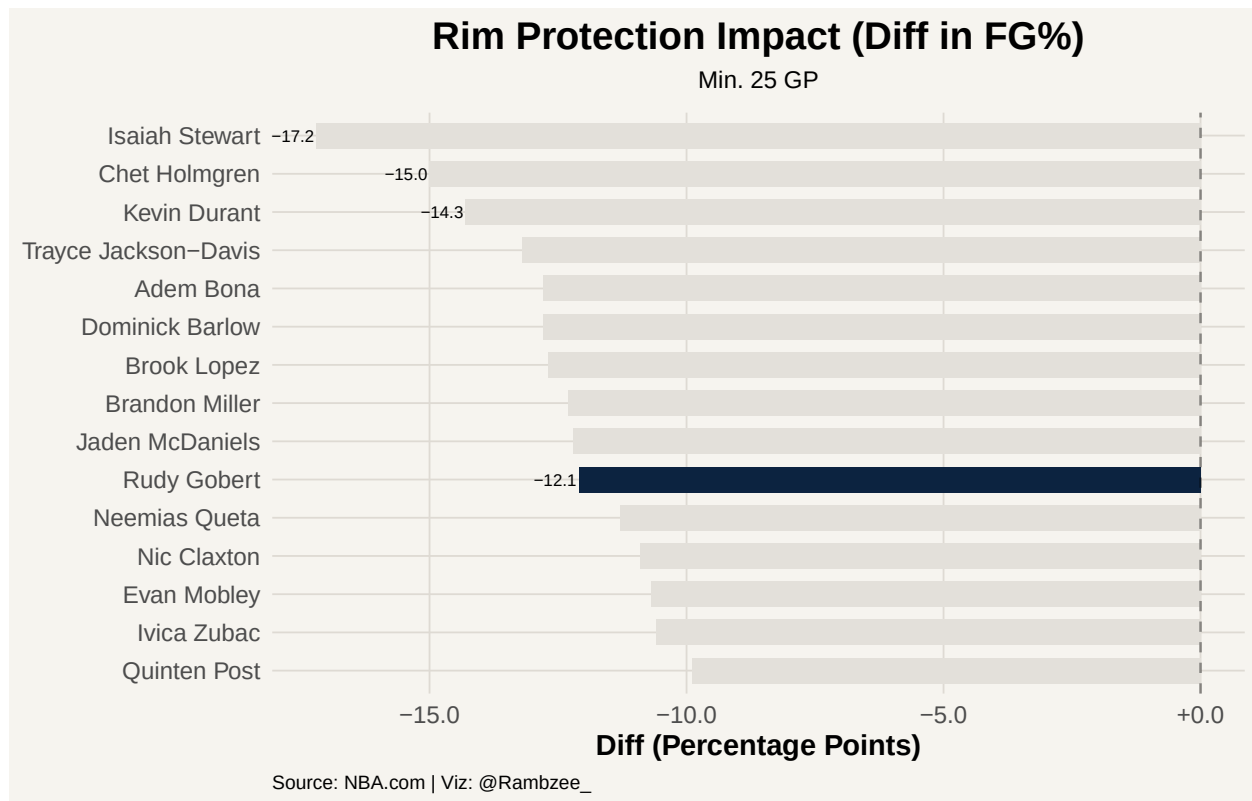


Figure 2: Defensive FG% impact (all shots). Diff = Opp FG% minus Expected FG% in percentage points. Lower is better.

On the all-shots leaderboard Gobert is still an elite defender by raw differential. He is defending the second-highest volume of attempts in the league (708), behind only Donovan Clingan. Night after night he absorbs heavy rim traffic and still holds shooters below expectation, even if his impact is not as flashy or versatile as Wembanyama's.

3.4 Rim-only DFG% Diff Leaderboard



At the rim, Gobert ranks 10th among high-volume protectors, holding shooters to 51.2% versus an expected 63.3% while carrying one of the league's heaviest defensive loads. That's why Minnesota treats him as the backbone of its defense.

3.5 Opp FG% rank at rim

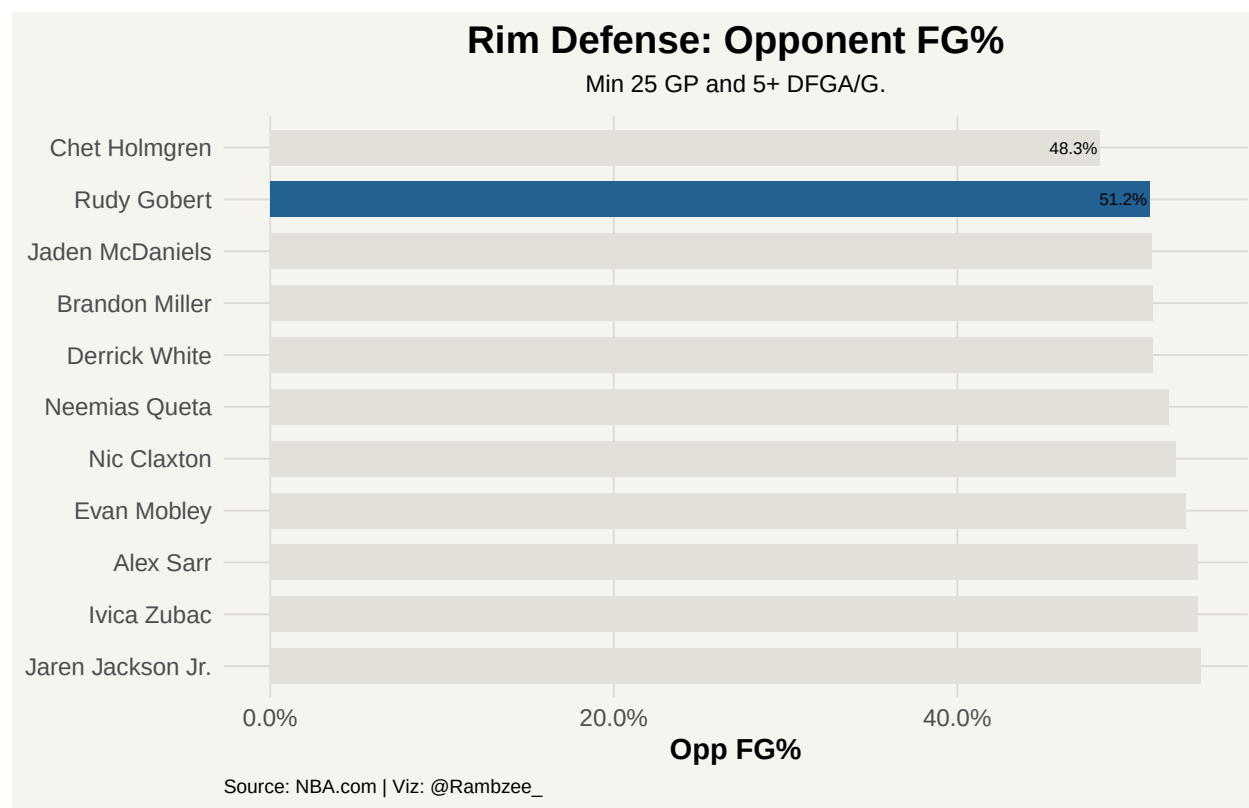


Figure 3: Rim defense: opponent FG% at the rim (<6 ft). Min 25 GP and 5+ DFGA/G.

Among players defending at least five rim shots per game, Gobert ranks second, holding shooters to 51.2%, behind only Chet Holmgren at 48.3%. Minnesota funnels traffic to him by design, and he still wins more often than not.

4 DPOY Case & Conclusion

Gobert's DPOY case is strong even with voter fatigue working against him. Minnesota is a bottom-tier defense the moment he sits (123.4 DRTG, worse than last-place Utah) and would rank second league-wide when he plays (108.1). That creates roughly a -15.3 defensive on/off swing, the kind of impact you normally only see on offense by superstars like Jokić or SGA.

Chet Holmgren has been brilliant, but his defensive on/off only sits around -0.3. Gobert is delivering superstar-level impact on defense, not offense. Meanwhile, his French counterpart Wembanyama remains likely to miss the games threshold altogether.